

Lost cause

Despite their efforts, US forces failed to slow, let alone stop, traffic down the Ho Chi Minh Trail. Infiltration accelerated over the years, reaching 20,000 tons of war materiel per month by the late 1960s. At one point, US aerial surveillance detected 15,000 vehicles on the trail in a single day. Thousands of American and South Vietnamese soldiers and airmen were killed or injured trying to interdict the trail, an effort akin to holding back the tide.

» AFTER

The Ho Chi Minh Trail played a role in all major offensives until the end of the war.

THE TRAIL GOES ON

The Ho Chi Minh Trail was used to position men and equipment for the 1968 **Tet Offensive**, North Vietnam's 1972 **Easter Offensive**, and the **Spring Offensive** of 1975. In 1971, South Vietnamese forces tried but failed to sever the trail in **Operation Lam Son 719**. Today, the modern vestiges of the trail provide an interior highway for Vietnam, bringing economic development.